

Day 4 — Sacred Groves: Community Biodiversity Reserves

Module: Indic Ecology · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students explain what a sacred grove is (community-protected forest fragment) using two regional terms — *devarakāḍu* (Karnataka) and *sarna* (tribal Eastern India) — and identify the ecological function of these groves as biodiversity reserves.

Materials

- A handful of photographs of sacred groves — the *kāvu* of Kerala, the *devarakāḍu* of Coorg, the *sarna* of Jharkhand. (Internet image search; teacher prepares ~6 images.)
- Printed handout: a 1-paragraph extract from Gadgil & Vartak (1976) on the function of sacred groves
- Map of India with sacred-grove regions marked (teacher prepares)

Vocabulary

- *devarakāḍu* (IAST: *devarakāḍu*; lit. “god’s forest,” Kannada) — sacred forest patch dedicated to a village deity, traditionally protected by community rule.
- *sarna* (*sarnā* in some dialects) — sacred grove in the *Adivasi* belt (Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha), centred on the *sal* tree and tribal deities.
- *kāvu* — sacred grove in Kerala (Malayalam).
- *orans* — sacred grove / pasture in Rajasthan.
- *biodiversity* — the variety of living species in a particular area.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Project one photograph of a sacred grove (dense, untouched, surrounded by cleared agricultural land).
- “*What do you notice about this patch of forest compared to what’s around it?*” Take 2–3 responses.
- “*Why might this small patch have survived when the surrounding forest was cut?*” Take 2–3 hypotheses. Don’t resolve.

Core (20 min)

1. **Define a sacred grove.** A patch of forest — anywhere from a few trees to several hectares — protected by community rule because of a religious association: a village deity, a goddess, an ancestor, a snake-shrine, a tree itself. The protection takes the form of taboos: no tree-cutting, no twig-collection, no hunting, sometimes no entry except on festival days.

2. **Where they survive.** Sacred groves exist across India:

Region	Local name	Notes
Karnataka (Coorg)	<i>devarakāḍu</i>	~1,200 documented groves; surveyed by Madhav Gadgil's team in the 1970s–90s.
Kerala	<i>kāvu</i>	Often associated with snake deities (<i>sarpa-kāvu</i>).
Maharashtra (Western Ghats)	<i>devarāī</i>	Surveyed by Gadgil & Vartak in their 1976 paper.
Jharkhand / Odisha / W. Bengal (tribal belt)	<i>sarna</i>	Centred on <i>sal</i> (<i>Shorea robusta</i>); tied to Adivasi worship.
Rajasthan	<i>orans</i>	Often combined with grazing land for community livestock.
Meghalaya (Khasi Hills)	<i>law kyntang</i>	Some of the largest and best-protected groves in India.

3. **Why they matter ecologically.** Read the handout extract:

“Sacred groves are relict patches of original vegetation conserved through cultural-religious tradition. They function as in-situ refuges for plant species lost from surrounding areas, including medicinal plants and old-growth trees of high genetic value. In the Western Ghats, sacred groves harbour species not found in nearby agricultural or even reserve-forest landscapes.” — paraphrased from Gadgil, M. & Vartak, V. D. (1976), “The Sacred Groves of Western Ghats in India,” *Economic Botany* 30(2): 152–160.

4. **The mechanism, plainly stated.** When a community treats a patch of forest as sacred, the patch survives. When the community stops, the patch goes the way of any unprotected land — into agriculture or development. Sacred groves are a *social* protection technology, not a biological accident.
5. **Modern parallel.** Modern ecology has a name for this same phenomenon: “community-managed conservation areas” or “biocultural refugia.” The UN’s Convention on Biological Diversity recognises Indigenous and Community Conserved Areas (ICCAs). The Indic *devarakāḍu* and the *sarna* are some of the oldest documented examples of what global conservation policy now formally recommends.

Frame this carefully: *we are not saying “ancient Indians invented modern conservation.”* We are saying multiple cultures, including the Indic tradition, arrived at similar protective practices for similar reasons. The recognition is mutual, not a claim to priority.

Activity (15 min) — Sacred Grove Mapping

(See [activities/activity-01-sacred-grove-mapping.md](#) for the full sheet.)

In groups of 4: - One student looks up your state's sacred-grove tradition (Coorg / Kerala / Jharkhand / etc.). One paragraph. - One student lists three species you would expect to find in a 200-year-old undisturbed forest patch in your bio-region. - One student draws what a "school sacred grove" could look like — even a 10-tree patch in a campus corner. - One student writes a one-sentence rule the group would adopt to keep their imaginary grove protected.

Groups present in 30 seconds each.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- **Daily prompt.** *"Do you know of any patch of land near you — even a small one — that has been protected for unusual reasons?"* (A graveyard. A shrine. A temple compound. A lawyer's office's overgrown corner.) Each of these may function as an accidental biodiversity refuge.
- Preview Day 5: *"Tomorrow we read the Bhagavad Gītā on why giving back is built into the ecological cycle."*

Student-facing content

Sacred groves are patches of forest that survived because a community treated them as religious — and that religious status meant rules against cutting and hunting.

Local names you should know:

- *devarakāḍu* — Karnataka
- *sarna* — Adivasi belt (Jharkhand, etc.)
- *kāvu* — Kerala
- *orans* — Rajasthan

In the Western Ghats, ecologists have documented more than 1,000 sacred groves. Some are only a few trees; some are several hectares. Together they preserve plants and animals that survive nowhere else in their region.

The same idea — community-protected conservation areas — is now formally recommended by the UN's Convention on Biological Diversity (Indigenous and Community Conserved Areas, or ICCAs).

Homework

- Ask one elder in your family or neighbourhood: *"Was there any tree, grove, pond, or piece of land that was 'not to be touched' when you were a child? What happened to it?"* Write what they said in 5 sentences. Bring tomorrow.

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Find one news story from the last 5 years about a sacred grove being threatened (a road, a mine, a township). Summarise in a paragraph. We'll add it to Day 7's discussion.

- **One tier down:** Just remember two regional names (*devarakāḍu* and *sarna*) and one fact: sacred groves preserve species the surrounding land has lost.

Teacher notes

- Some students will challenge: “*That’s superstition. Why should we protect a forest because of a goddess?*” — affirm the question. Answer: it doesn’t matter *why* a community protects a forest; what matters is that it gets protected. The Indic tradition used the language of the sacred. Modern conservation uses the language of “ecosystem services.” Both are descriptions of the same protective behaviour.
- The Coorg *devarakāḍu* network is well-documented; the figure of ~1,200 groves is from Gadgil’s published surveys. If you want a source, Gadgil & Subash Chandran (1991) is a more recent count.
- Don’t romanticise sacred groves as universally protected. Many have been encroached, paved over, or turned into commercial temples. The protection is real where it is sustained; it is not magical.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- **Gadgil, M. & Vartak, V. D.** (1976). “The Sacred Groves of Western Ghats in India.” *Economic Botany* 30(2): 152–160. — Paraphrased in the handout.
- See [sources.md](#) for the full reference and the Chapple & Tucker (2000) anthology if you need teacher background.